of Shams al-Dunya wa al-Din (Figures 4.13 and 4.14), continues with parts of verses 23–24 of Surat al-Hashr (Q. LIX), which was also part of the epigraphy on Shah-i Mashhad's northern entrance, and whose frequent presence on epitaphs, and funerary *stelae* and architecture has already been noted (cf. notes above).

The western structure's Kufic inscription (Figure 4.15) contains the common verses 255–257 from Surat al-Baqara (Q. II), among which is the famous Throne verse (Q. II: 256). The text continues with verses 18–19 from Surat Al 'Imran (Q. III), "the most popular Koranic text on monuments from early Islamic Iran."[77] As if by deliberate contrast, the Kufic inscription progresses with verses 1–3 from Surat al-Ikhlas (Q. CXII), which were undocumented in Blair's inscriptional corpus of the eastern Islamic lands from the ninth through early twelfth centuries, but common particularly in funerary contexts (mainly epitaphs) from the ninth century onward in Egypt, and also in Iran and the Red Sea coast of northeast Africa.[78]

Furthermore, a consideration of the directional orientation of the Chisht complex (Figure 4.16) and an examination of the site's broader historical context, together provide a fascinating if complicated picture of multiple *madhhab*s active in the region, probably through indirect means. First, the orientation of the *mihrab* within Chisht's northeastern structure could hint at a Hanafi affiliation for the complex, or at least a portion of it. As discussed in relation to Shah-i Mashhad (cf. above), pre-modern *qibla* orientations were calculated largely by means of "folk astronomy," in which the preferred *qibla*s of regionally dominant *madhhab*s were among the determining factors. While the Shafi'is were known to use a south-oriented *qibla*, Hanafi *qibla*s tended to be oriented west. The Chisht complex's nearly north–south axis could have accommodated either or both orientations, similar to the layout of Shah-i Mashhad. But at Chisht, the surviving *mihrab* in the northeast structure has a westerly orientation, thereby seeming to dispel any ambiguity in favor of a Hanafi affiliation.

Finally, it is possible that, particularly *if* there was a Hanafi-affiliated presence at the Chisht complex, other *madhhab*s were also active in the vicinity, if not directly then through a type of surrogate representation. Chisht was certainly within the ambit of the Khurasani commercial center of Herat, only 150 km to the west, which in turn was well connected with Nishapur and other such great emporia beyond. But as noted earlier in this chapter, the direct influence of the city-based *madhhab*s was considerably diluted in the hinterlands, precisely where the more intrepid activists among the Karramiyya had identified proselytizing opportunities.

The Karramiyya were not alone, however, in their unorthodox proselytizing methods in both urban and hinterland milieus (cf. above in this chapter). Charismatic spiritual masters or Sufis (also *pir*, *murshid*) – identifiable by a characteristic woolen cloak (*suf*) or other mark of poverty – were also gathering followers devoted to their teachings, in cities such as